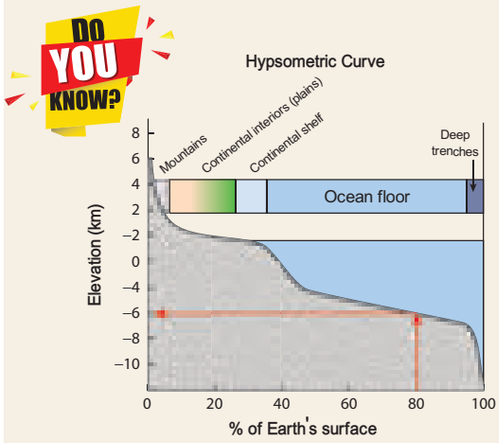


A Hypsometric Curve is a graphic representation which shows the height of a certain place found on land and the height of ocean features at sea.

'Hypso' means height in Greek.

The continental shelf is of great significance for the following reasons:

- They are shallower, thus enables sunlight to penetrate through the water. This encourages abundant growth of grass, sea weeds and plankton. Hence these zones become the **richest fishing grounds** in the world. Eg. The **Grand Banks of Newfoundland**.
- The continental shelves have extensive deposits of minerals and mineral fuels. Hence, this zone becomes accessible for oil drilling and mining activities. E.g. Mumbai High in Arabian Sea.

Geo Connect



ONGC: Oil and Natural Gas Corporation is India's largest oil and gas exploration and production company. Its latest estimate is that about 20 million tons of oil reserves are found west of Mumbai High off shore.

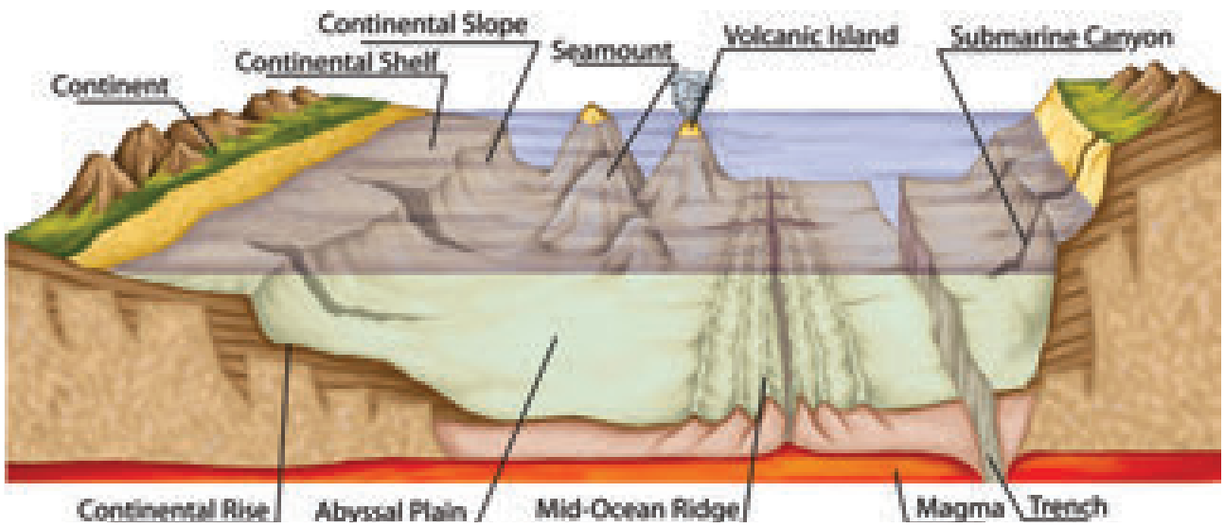
(B) Continental Slope

A steep slope which descends from the edge of the continental shelf to the deep ocean-bed is called continental slope. It forms a boundary between the Continental Crust and the oceanic crust. This zone is free from deposits as they are steep. The most important characteristic of continental slope is the **presence of deep canyons and trenches.** Due to the low penetration of sunlight, the slope has nearly freezing temperature. Hence aquatic life has very slow rate of metabolism.

(C) Continental Rise

At the base of the continental slope is a gently sloping layer of sediments which merge into the deep-sea floor. This underwater feature found between continental slope and abyssal plains is called the continental rise. It **consists of submarine fans** which are similar to the alluvial fans found on land.

Major Relief Features of the Ocean



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